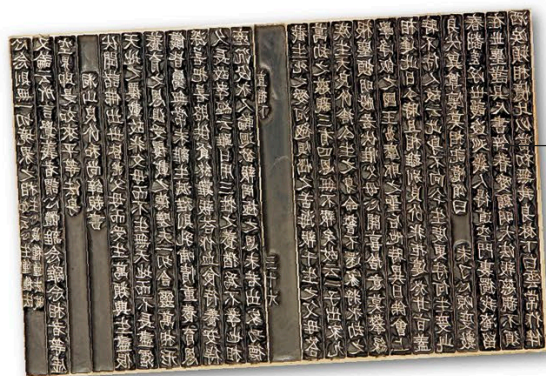


The printing revolution

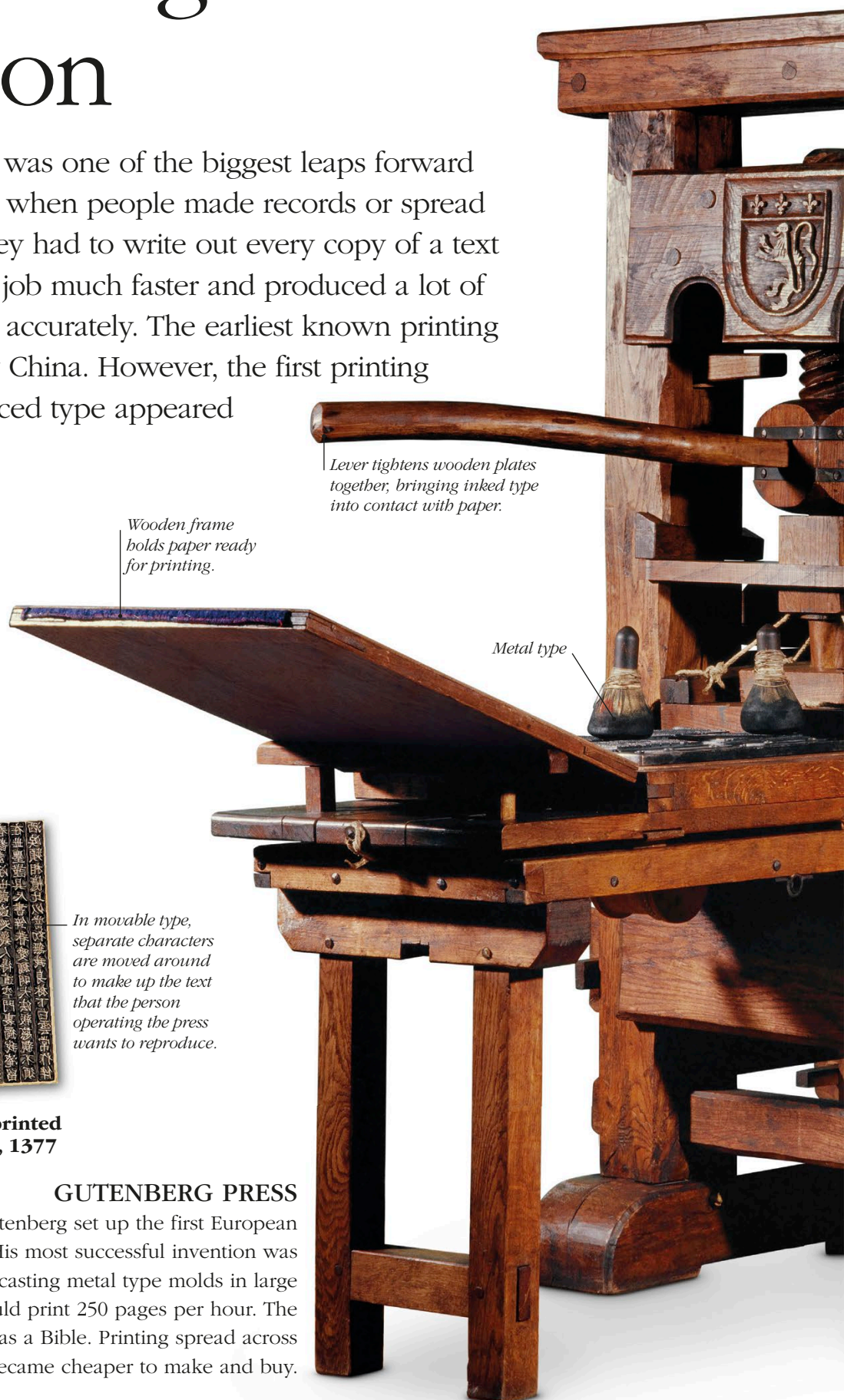
The invention of printing was one of the biggest leaps forward in human history. Before, when people made records or spread information and ideas, they had to write out every copy of a text by hand. Printing did the job much faster and produced a lot of copies more cheaply and accurately. The earliest known printing dates back to 3rd-century China. However, the first printing system using mass-produced type appeared in Europe in 1439.

METAL MOVABLE TYPE

Movable type is a system where molds of separate letters (or characters) are used to print text. The first-ever movable type was made in China in the 11th century CE, using clay or wooden character molds. Later, people found that metal was the best material for making type.



Jikji, the oldest surviving book printed using metal movable type, Korea, 1377



Wooden frame holds paper ready for printing.

Lever tightens wooden plates together, bringing inked type into contact with paper.

Metal type

In movable type, separate characters are moved around to make up the text that the person operating the press wants to reproduce.

GUTENBERG PRESS

The German Johannes Gutenberg set up the first European printing press in 1439. His most successful invention was a method of rapidly casting metal type molds in large quantities. Gutenberg could print 250 pages per hour. The first book he produced was a Bible. Printing spread across Europe, and books became cheaper to make and buy.